STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 22 · Give Your Son a Name

Transcript · Wes Hart

Hey. Come on in and sit. Good to see this room. Uh, some of you walked in still wearing the day. You came anyway. I see you. Last time we stayed with a daughter who's watching. How you treat her mother. What she learns to trust. A few of you went home and got profound at the table. She asked for the salt. You gave her a speech. She still wanted the salt. I've given that speech. So. Today the boy. If you still need it, I'm Wes. Glad you made the chair. Uh, some of you have a boy who still fits under your arm. Uh, some of you have a grown one who lets the phone ring. Some of you are still waiting for a man to tell you who you are. Stay in the chair. All of you have a mouth. That's the tool today. Uh, you don't have to feel ready to use it. Most of us didn't. Uh, we learned it on a day that felt ordinary. Some of you will say it to your own boy before supper. Some of you will say it to a boy who is not yours, and it counts the same. Here's what I want sitting in the room. A boy answers to whatever he is called. If you don't name your son, the world will. It has a label ready before lunch, and most of those labels are cheap. You can— you can be around him all day and still be a quiet stranger to the boy who carries your name. There's a name on the mailbox. The one I'm after is the sentence he lives under when nobody is performing. Uh, this is a habit. Catch one true thing he did. Call it by its right name. Put a hand on his head and say what you actually see. Uh, if there is no son in the house, there is a younger man in reach. He has ears. You are on this with the rest of us.

These four marks are the sentence we keep coming back to. I have not improved them. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. You've heard them in this room, right? Uh, I am not rebuilding all four today. Today is the mouth. The marks tell you what the word man has to hold when you finally say it over a boy. Stop waiting. Uh, that includes a father who lets every other voice name his son and calls the quiet peace. Pick up the weight. Uh, the sentences in your house are yours, including the ones you did not rehearse. Go first. Say the true thing out loud, where it could sound soft, and say it anyway. Work for God's pay. Not the room's. The easy quiet you get from never blessing him is a thin peace. The Father sees the man who opens his mouth. Uh, I have loved the quiet. Uh, nobody argues. Nobody gets blessed either. That quiet can look like peace from the driveway. Here's the claim under the marks. A boy lives toward the name he hears most. Uh, you can provide, and drive, and show up, and still hand him a small name. Or you can love him by giving him one he can stand on. Uh, I know which one I drift toward. Ask me what time practice is. I have it. Ask me who my boy is becoming, and I start talking about what we're out of at the house. Milk. We were out of milk. Uh, logistics feel like fathering. They even fit on a list. A list is not a name. Uh, stay with me on this. The name comes first. The errand can come along after it. You already know how to handle a list. Today you learn the sentence.

Put this verse in your ear. You'll see it in the workbook. Isaiah forty-three, verse one. But now, this is what the Lord says. He who created you, Jacob, he who formed you, Israel. Do not fear, for I have redeemed you. I have summoned you by name. You are mine. Summoned you by name. You are mine. Uh, a father who will not open his mouth leaves a hole shaped like that sentence. Uh, holes do not stay empty. Some other name moves in. Uh, I learned the hole at my own house. I could tell you his shoe size. I could tell you what he was late on. From the hall I called the mess. Shoes. The thing on the floor. He'd answer before I finished, already making his case. I thought— I thought I was running a house. I was teaching him his name was whatever was wrong. Uh, other mouths are already at work. School has a label ready. Uh, not always mean. The one who can't keep still. The one who reads late. A teacher says it sideways, and a boy close enough will rent that word for years. The air around him gets nervous about boys. It talks about him like a spill somebody ought to wipe up before he spreads. He hears it. He gets smaller, or he decides to become the warning. Uh, his own misses will name him if no man steps in. He quits a job halfway. Nobody pulls the act off the boy. I don't finish. That's just how I am. Hardware aisle. Uh, my boy handed me the wrong bolt. I said, use your head, and the tone meant, you're the slow one. He set it back on the hook like he'd taken something. I left with the right bolt. I did not leave with the sentence repaired. I still know the aisle. How many of you have a shortcut like that. A noise from one bad afternoon that stuck because it was easy. Go on. I'm in it with you. Yeah. I figured. Fast names. Slow blessings. An easy name is still a name. He will answer to it. You are mine is how a father answers back. A floor under whatever else gets said.

So the first name you give him, on purpose, is mine. You are my son. I am staying. He has not earned that sentence. He does not have to. No bad afternoon evicts him from it. Uh, say it when the day went well. Say it— say it when the day was a wreck. If you only say it on the good days, he learns that belonging is a wage. Uh, I waited for a mood. The mood where I felt like the patient man in a picture. The mood did not show up. Uh, moods are terrible managers. The boy still needed the sentence on a tired Thursday when he was loud and I was done. You are my son. I am in this with you. That is the whole speech some evenings. It is enough to start a floor. Uh, say it again the next evening. Same words. He starts to trust the repeat. The Father does not wait on a résumé. Isaiah says summoned. Then mine. Belonging goes first. A boy who is sure of you can miss a tryout, miss a friendship, miss a grade, and still find the table. A boy who is not sure spends his life reading faces for a yes. A coach. A boss. A room that goes quiet when he walks in. Somebody he is trying hard to impress. Uh, I have watched a grown man still auditioning in a room like this. He laughs a little late. He's checking the faces. That habit starts young, and it starts at home. If you are the son who never heard mine, hear me kindly. Uh, this is not a bit about your old man. Some of you are still waiting on a sentence that did not come. You can tell the truth about that. You can also give the sentence you did not get. Don't leave the chair because the house you came from was thin on words. Your mouth is still yours.

The second name is what you see in him. The person. Character, spoken while the scoreboard is still blank. You catch him being the thing God is forming, and you say the word before he has a name for it. Uh, then growth has a direction. He stays on a messy job after the others have wandered off. You say, that's faithfulness. I see it. You didn't leave the hard part for somebody else. He steps between a smaller kid and a joke that turned mean. You say, that's courage. You used your size to cover him. Uh, call it often enough, and a cheap shot starts to feel wrong in his hands. If the only word he hears is the miss, he has nothing to push off of. Name the character, and the miss has a road home. Judges six. Gideon is hiding. He is threshing wheat in a winepress so the Midianites won't see the food. And the angel says, Judges six, verse twelve, The Lord is with you, mighty warrior. Mighty warrior. While the man is underground with the grain. The name arrives before the proof. God does that. A father does a small, steady copy. You see the faithful man while the boy still feels like the kid who hid. Uh, don't invent a compliment he can't cash. False names make him distrust the real ones. You saw a real act. You name that act. You tie it to the man he is becoming. Uh, I have swallowed this. School line, cars inching. My boy had stayed beside a kid who was getting left out of the game. I had— I had the sentence. I'm proud of the way you stayed. What came out was, buckle up, we're behind. He buckled. The other sentence is still mine. I didn't spend it. A name you keep in your mouth is a name you did not give.

The third name is the one a lot of us missed. Man. Somewhere he can still remember, he needs his father to say, you are becoming a man, and here is what that word holds. Then you give him the marks. From your mouth. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Uh, he is already asking. Am I one yet. If you stay quiet, some other voice will be glad to answer. Uh, I have watched the substitutes. A scoreboard that finally lights up. A crew that lets him in if he learns to be cruel enough. A look from somebody he wanted, and he takes the look as a verdict. A number in an account that makes him feel finished. Those will name him. They are happy to do it. Uh, he will be called a man by somebody. Decide that the somebody is you. Say it early. You don't have to wait for a ceremony you keep moving down the calendar. I can tell you what was expected of me as a kid. Chores. Grades. Don't embarrass the family. I cannot hand you a sentence where a man told me what a man is. Uh, so I borrowed. Work. Being hard to rattle. Keeping my mouth shut and calling the silence strength. Uh, it carried me a long way. It did not tell my son who he is. I'm not building a case against the house I grew up in. I'm telling you the gap is real. A gap does not raise a boy. A sentence does. Uh, say it before the substitutes do. Fill the word while it is still good news. He is listening for a definition. You answer. On purpose. More than once. Until the word man, in his ear, sounds like those four marks and he can say them back.

A habit does this work. A speech on a big day cannot carry it. Each day, catch one act a man would recognize, and say the name of it. Uh, he took the smaller piece and didn't announce himself. That's humility. He finished the job after you left the garage. That's faithfulness. It takes

less time than finding your keys. Uh, it may be the richest thing you spend on him. Then one evening you already decided. Not when you feel holy. Uh, hand on his head. Three sentences. You are my son. I love you. I am in your corner. Here is what I saw. Name the real thing. Tie it to the man. God made you on purpose. There is good work that fits you. I will help you look for it. Uh, the first time, it will feel strange. Mine did. I put a hand on his head and it felt like a play, so I turned it into a hair ruffle and a good job. He got a pat. He needed a sentence. The pat was easier on me. Uh, easy is how a boy stays unnamed. Another evening I got the three sentences out. He waited. Then he said, am I in trouble. When he fails, pull the act off the boy. Don't hand him the failure as a name. Say he shoved a smaller kid to get a laugh from the older ones. You don't close the file with, you're a bully. You say— you say, you are my son. Using somebody smaller for a laugh was cruel. Here is the next move my son makes. You go back. You make it right with that boy, and I stand there with you. Uh, praise where people can hear it. Correct behind a door. At the table, this is my son, and he kept his word. The wrong thing does not get an audience. Shame in a crowd sticks as a name. Praise in a crowd lifts as one.

Let me tell you about a man I'll call Troy. He sat with a few of us. Good man. Showed up. His boy was about twelve, youngest in a pile of cousins who treated every job like a contest. They were building a low ramp for a woman at their church who couldn't manage the steps. Older boys had work with names. Measure. Cut. Drive the screws. Troy's boy got sent. Water. The other board. The bit somebody lost in the grass. Uh, when the boy got waved off, Troy laughed with them. He told me he laughed because everybody else did, and he didn't want to be the heavy on a kind afternoon. That night he heard his boy on the back steps, talking to a kid from down the street who had come to watch. The neighbor kid said, what do you do out there. Troy's boy said, I go get stuff. He said it like a job he had accepted. Proud, and small, in the same breath. Troy stood in the kitchen and felt sick. At his own laugh. The next afternoon they were back on the ramp. The bracket wouldn't sit. Older boys hit the snag and went for the cooler. The boy stayed. Knuckles scraped. No crowd he was playing to. Troy walked over. The cousins could hear. He almost— he almost made a joke, because the joke was right there. He said, you stayed with the hard piece. That's steadiness. That's a man's kind of patience. The boy didn't know where to put his face. One of the cousins snorted. Troy didn't pick it up. He said it again, quieter, just to his son. I meant that. Some time later that neighbor kid had quit his own chore, embarrassed. Troy's boy told him, come back. Staying is the part that counts. You don't have to be fast. Troy didn't assign that speech. The boy had a word, and he spent it on somebody smaller. Uh, the old pattern didn't die before supper. Patterns are stubborn. The boy stopped describing himself as the one who goes and gets. He had a better sentence, and it came from his father, out loud, where the other males could hear it.

Hear me on the chair you are actually in. If the boy in your house is still a baby, start. He cannot use the words yet. He knows the voice. When you lift him in the dark, say, you are my son. Uh, new fathers feel useless with an infant. The name is the work. Uh, if the marriage came apart,

he may be hearing other names across town. You cannot run that house. He is not the mail between two adults. When you have him, give him a sentence he can count. You are my son. I love you. The address does not change it. Daughters at home, and no son. You still have boys in reach. A nephew. The boy you coach. The kid who stays because his ride is late. Last time was the girl. A boy can hear you on this. Young, and nobody has named you yet. You are not late. Uh, you are not sitting this out. Spend a true name on a younger man while you are still growing into yours. If the work is going well, your name may be on a door. The boy still gets a hey from the hall. He will— he will believe the door until your mouth tells him who he is. Older men. A grown son still has ears. If you never said what you see in him, say it. Late is still a gift. I'll call him Len. His son was past thirty, doing better, quiet about it. Len had told everybody but the son. They were loading mulch into a car. Len said, I'm proud of the man you've become. The son held the bag. Didn't look up. Then he said, I wasn't sure you thought I made it. Uh, Len told me he was glad the bag was heavy. He needed somewhere for his hands. Never had a son. You are not the mascot in the corner. Uh, see a boy do a man's thing. Say it where the other boys can hear. One true sentence, in the light. If you were named by a wound, go slow. I will not make that funny, and I will not make the wound your whole name. A younger man in reach still has ears.

What you speak over him is a small copy of what God speaks over sons. Mine. What he sees. A man, under Christ. He says that kind of claiming over every man who is in Christ. Over you. Whether a father ever managed the words or not. Isaiah again. I have summoned you by name. You are mine. That was not invented for a hallway. It holds over a son. It holds over the man who never heard it at home. Uh, you can receive it today, even if the first voice in your life never got around to it. A boy can survive a hard day. A house with no sentence in it is the harder thing. Say it while he is still in reach. Out loud beats a plan you keep. You will fail at this. You will spend the cheap name when you are tired. Come back. Uh, repair the sentence. A repaired sentence teaches him something a spotless record never could. It teaches him that a man returns. And you will not be here forever. Uh, your voice is a covering. It is meant to point past you. Aim him at the Father who does not leave. That is the best use of your name. If you are the son who never received this, you are still allowed to give it. I kept— I kept waiting to feel like the kind of man who could put a hand on a head without feeling like a fraud. Uh, the feeling did not lead. The sentence did. I became a little more of that man by saying the thing before I felt qualified. Uh, start before you feel ready. Let the words work on both of you. Uh, he is asking who he is. On a lot of ordinary days. You may be holding the answer he will actually keep. Give him one he can plant his feet on long after your voice goes quiet.

Let me land it. A boy answers to whatever he is called. If you don't name your son, the world will, and the world has no good names for boys. Three names, from your mouth, on repeat. Mine. What I see in you. Man. Mine is belonging. He has not earned it, and he is not up for eviction. What I see is character, tied to a real act, spoken while he is still growing into it. Man is the

word filled on purpose. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Keep that line close. What I hope you walk out with is a mouth that has decided. You know what he has been hearing. You know the name you mean to give. Your workbook is where this gets particular. Uh, in a minute you'll sit at the tables and work this part together. Get the questions in your ear. What has your son been hearing from you, even if the honest answer is a sigh or an eye roll? What names have you been giving without meaning to? Where will you catch him, and where will you put a hand on his head and say the three sentences? A son in the house, or a younger man in reach. Both of you own the page. Tell a brother the names you have been giving without meaning to. Ask what his father called him. Ask what he is calling his own son. If there is no son, you still tell one man. Name the younger man out loud. Each day, catch one thing a man does and give it its name. One night, hand on his head, three sentences. No son in the house? Name one act you watched a boy do, out loud, where it can land. Carry this, and write it where you will see it. A boy answers to whatever he is called. If you don't name your son, the world will, and the world has no good names for boys. Give him one he can stand on. Then go to your tables. Work this part of the workbook together.